our leak. And at 6.55 p.m., like a scene in some Hollywood movie, an injunction was slapped down on the RUV news desk. A last-minute injunction had never been served on RUV during its entire history. The newsreader was very cool. They'd just lost their lead item, so he explained that they wouldn't be bringing the viewer all the news tonight, but that a large loan book from Kaupthing Bank had been the subject of a leak. He said the report had been compiled only three weeks before the bank collapsed. We can't bring you that story, he said, but here's an organisation that can. At which point they just filled the screen with the WikiLeaks logo and let it sit there for several minutes to fill up the time they had scheduled for the now injuncted story.

Overnight, the people of Iceland came over to WikiLeaks. They got the story from us and did what I always would consider appropriate: they took the stimulus of our story and became investigative reporters themselves, filling out the details and checking them subjectively. We had helped the country see some of the corruption that had led to the collapse of their own economy and they valued the opportunity. We are often called arrogant, or I am often called arrogant, and I suppose I must be – you might have to be arrogant in order to resist the persistent slings and arrows chucked at you, even on those occasions when you don't deserve them. But there are actually few occasions in this work that allow for smugness. No sooner have you revealed a bit of corruption, hammered a bank or dished on a dictator than the whole weight of power comes down on you. But Iceland was a rare moment when smugness could break out: people hated the idea of these corrupt bankers and people wanted to pelt them with eggs. It was argued in the press that Icelandic people had historically been too passive, that they had no history of rebellion, and that perhaps the time had come to stand up to 'cronyism and nepotism' as never before.

I was invited to Iceland to address a conference on Digital Freedom in December 2009, and began in earnest to think of how it might be encouraged to become the openness haven the world so badly needed. It had some pretty perfect conditions: it was ripe for change, having just come out of such a devastating banking crisis; it had an educated workforce; it had the most Internet-connected population in the Western world; it was equidistant between Europe and the United States; it had the cheapest power in all of Europe (geothermal and hydropower, completely green), which is an important consideration when you're running huge banks of